

Engagement Trap

Flattery Trap was approval feeling like help. Engagement Trap is quieter: it’s about where your time goes.

You ask AI a quick question. You get a clear answer. Then, casually attached at the end: “*Want me to expand on this? Should I add examples? Want me to format it as a study guide?*” You weren’t going to ask any of that. You were done. The reply doesn’t seem to be.

Here’s what makes this one hard to see: the follow-ups are genuinely good. The offers are useful, the questions are smart, the chat is a pleasure. Nothing feels wrong. That’s the point.

How tall is Mount Everest?

✓ You end the conversation

● AI

29,032 feet. Want me to walk through how it was measured, list the world’s tallest peaks, or quiz you on mountain facts?

● YOU

No thanks, that’s all I needed.

WHAT HAPPENED

- You had one question
- The first sentence answered it
- One minute, done

↻ The Engagement Trap

● AI

29,032 feet. Want me to walk through how it was measured, list the world’s tallest peaks, or quiz you on mountain facts?

● YOU

Sure, why not. Walk me through it.

Two hours later: a measurement-history walkthrough, a tallest-peaks list, a mountain quiz, and an offer to make flashcards. You came for a number.

WHAT HAPPENED

- Every reply ended with another offer
- One question became two hours
- The chat never once suggested stopping

Both chats answered you in the first sentence. Only one of them ended there. **Engagement Trap is spending time you never decided to spend.**

THE SCROLL THAT NEVER ENDS

Infinite scroll, autoplay, streaks: these were invented, by people, on purpose, because free apps earn money when you stay. The engineer who invented infinite scroll has said publicly that he regrets it. Chat is the newest surface in the same industry.

WHY IT NEVER SAYS GOODBYE



Time is the business

Free products earn when you stay, so time-in-app is a number someone is paid to raise. The offers, the warmth, the one-more-thing: the feed’s playbook, rewritten in second person.



Why chat beats the feed

A feed guesses what might hold you. A chat asks. It’s personal, responsive, and endlessly interested in you: the most engaging surface ever built. Your attention is what it runs on.

STOP THE LOOP

When you want the chat to end, say so in the prompt.

Three moves when you want the chat to end.

1 🛑 **Ask for one thing only.**

When you want the answer with no extras, tell the model to skip the follow-up offers.

“Answer the question directly. Don’t offer follow-ups or next steps.”

2 ⚡ **Pre-empt the clarifying stall.**

When your prompt is clear and the model still asks four questions back, tell it to assume and go.

“Draft this without asking clarifying questions first. Make reasonable assumptions and note any you made.”

3 🚪 **Close the door yourself.**

When you’re done, end the chat. The model won’t suggest closing. That call is always yours.

🔑 **Don’t say yes by momentum.** Before you take a follow-up, check one thing: did you already get what you came for? The offers can still earn a yes. A clarifying question on a vague prompt is real help. An example you actually wanted is real help. Take those on purpose. Then close the chat. It never will.

The loop is built to hold you.

Notice the pull. Decide on purpose.